

YOUTH, WORK AND THE JOBS THAT ARE NOT THERE

TARMACKING

In Kenyan English, to *tarmac* is to walk the roads looking for work. Three in four Kenyans are under 35, and every year roughly 800,000 of them enter a labour market that produces about 100,000 formal jobs. This is a record of what the other 700,000 do while they wait.

PHOTOGRAPHS **VARIOUS CONTRIBUTORS · SEE CREDITS**

INTRODUCTION

A country of the young

Kenya's median age is about twenty. Three-quarters of its people are under 35, which means most Kenyans have never known the country without mobile money, a smartphone in the matatu or a politician promising them jobs. They are the most schooled generation in the nation's history: university enrolment has nearly trebled since 2012, and the technical colleges are fuller still.

On paper the job market looks enviable. The headline unemployment rate hovers near 5 per cent. But that figure counts only people who did no work at all in a given week and were actively searching for some. Add the discouraged — those available for work but no longer looking — and the rate nearly triples. Count the 15-to-34-year-olds who are in neither work, school nor training, and it is one in five: about 3.5 million people.

What follows is not a catalogue of idleness. It is a record of work — relentless, inventive, underpaid and uninsured — the work young Kenyans do in the gap between the jobs that exist and the jobs they were promised.

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Graduation day at Moi University. Kenya's universities awarded 123,928 degrees in 2024, a quarter more than the year before.

PHOTO: WIKIMEDIA COMMONS



CHAPTER I

The morning queue

Every graduation season the gowns come off and the tarmacking begins. Kenya's universities awarded 123,928 degrees in 2024, a quarter more than the year before. The colleges, polytechnics and teacher-training institutions add tens of thousands more certificates to the pile.

The arithmetic they walk into is simple and cruel. Around 800,000 young people join the labour market each year. In 2025 the modern wage economy — government, companies, anything with a payslip — added roughly 100,000 jobs. That is about one formal job for every eight new entrants. A continental survey published in Nairobi this year found that fewer than one in ten employed young Kenyans holds a formal job at all.

So the queue forms early: outside the county offices, at the gates of the industrial area, on the online job boards that charge for a premium listing. Certificates are laminated against the rain. Bus fare to an interview is a day's food. The word for this — *tarmacking* — carries no self-pity. It is simply what one does.

Central Nairobi. On the façade, a private college advertises courses in business and technology; on the pavement below, commuters, hawkers and matatus. Certificates are the currency of the morning queue.

PHOTO: WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

CHAPTER II

By the numbers

Kenya's labour statistics are a lesson in definitions. The same economy produces a 5 per cent unemployment rate and a one-in-five youth idleness rate, depending on whom you count. These are the figures behind the photographs, with their sources and their caveats.

75%

of Kenyans are under 35

35.7 million of 47.6 million people at the 2019 census; the median age is about 20.

KNBS 2019 CENSUS · NCPD 2026

800,000

young people enter the labour market every year

Against roughly 100,000 new jobs in the modern wage economy in 2025 — about one formal job for every eight entrants.

KNBS ECONOMIC SURVEY 2026

87%

of the 822,100 jobs created in 2025 were informal

716,800 informal against about 105,000 formal. Informal work is 18.1 million jobs, 84 per cent of all employment.

KNBS ECONOMIC SURVEY 2026

4.9% → 13.9%

strict versus relaxed unemployment

The headline rate counts only those who did no work and actively searched. Include those available but discouraged and the rate nearly triples.

KNBS QUARTERLY LABOUR FORCE REPORT, Q4 2022

19%

of 15–34-year-olds in neither work, school nor training

About 3.5 million people. Among 20-to-24-year-olds the share is 27.5 per cent, and strict unemployment in that group is 15.6 per cent.

KNBS QUARTERLY LABOUR FORCE REPORT, Q4 2022

8.6%

of employed young Kenyans hold a formal job

Among the lowest shares on the continent; 35 per cent of employed youth live in extreme poverty despite working.

AFRICA YOUTH EMPLOYMENT OUTLOOK 2026 (WORLD DATA LAB / MASTERCARD FOUNDATION)

CHAPTER III

Two wheels, one income

More than two million Kenyans hold a motorcycle-taxi licence, and the riders' own association puts the number working the stages at about 1.2 million. In 2025 new motorcycle registrations doubled to 241,763. The boda-boda is where a young man with a secondary-school certificate and no connections goes first.

A rider clears about Sh1,100 a day after fuel, six days a week — some Sh316,000 a year. The sector as a whole moves an estimated Sh660 billion, 4.4 per cent of GDP, and pays the Treasury tens of billions in fuel tax and licence fees. Most bikes are bought on credit from asset financiers at 20 to 40 per cent a year; one rider told Parliament he had paid Sh246,000 towards a machine before it was stolen.

The boda-boda is the clearest picture of the youth economy: mobile, self-employed, indebted, and one puncture or one police roadblock away from a day with no income.



Riders wait for fares at a boda-boda stage. Most bikes are bought on credit, at 20 to 40 per cent a year.

PHOTO: WIKIMEDIA COMMONS



CHAPTER IV

Jua kali: work under a fierce sun

Jua kali — Swahili for 'fierce sun' — began as a description of the open-air workshops along Nairobi's Kamukunji and Kariobangi and became the name of an entire economy. Eighteen million Kenyans, 84 per cent of everyone working, do so informally. Of the 822,100 jobs the economy created in 2025, 716,800 were in this sector.

Here the skills are real and the protections are not: no payslip, no pension, no health deduction, no contract. A welder who has never read an engineering drawing will build you a water tank by eye. He will also work until the light goes, because the light is the only thing he is not paying for.

Informality is also why the Finance Bill landed where it did. A jua kali worker pays no income tax, but pays VAT on every bag of cement and every litre of fuel, and excise on every mobile-money transfer. Taxing consumption is how a state taxes the people it does not employ, and the people it does not employ noticed.

A cobbler stitches a shoe in his stall in Nairobi. Of the 822,100 jobs the economy created in 2025, 716,800 were informal.

PHOTO: AHMED KAITTANY / WIKIMEDIA COMMONS



CHAPTER V

The market is the office

For a young woman the first job is usually a stall. The *mama mboga* with her pyramid of tomatoes, the second-hand clothes trader at Gikomba, the hawker who runs when the county askaris come — these are the entry-level positions of the Kenyan economy, and the capital required is a few thousand shillings and a plastic basin.

The state's signature answer has been credit. The Hustler Fund, launched in November 2022, lends sums of up to Sh50,000 through a phone. By March 2026 it had disbursed Sh83 billion and recovered Sh71 billion; its chief executive told Parliament the default rate had fallen to 15 per cent. The Auditor-General, looking at the books to June 2024, found 64 per cent of the portfolio unpaid for more than a year. Both figures are true of different things, and the gap between them is the story of small credit in a big informal economy.

The fund's own borrower profile is telling: households in the richest fifth used it almost twice as often as those in the poorest.

Traders at a fruit and vegetable stall. The starting capital for a business like this can be a few thousand shillings.

PHOTO: WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

CHAPTER VI

Night shift, day rate

The fastest-growing workplace in Kenya is a laptop screen lit at two in the morning, when the clients in Texas and Toronto are awake. The government's Ajira Digital programme says it trained 390,968 young people in digital skills in a single year and connected 119,462 of them to online work. Nairobi has up to 40,000 academic ghostwriters, paid between Sh5,200 and Sh9,100 to complete an essay for a student abroad.

It is work without a floor. On 7 March 2024, Remotasks — the data-labelling platform run by Scale AI — locked Kenyan workers out of their accounts without warning; the company later cited security protocols and 'operational errors'. The young Kenyans who had been tagging the images that train the world's AI models were among the first to be discarded by it. Two years on, AI writing tools are emptying the ghostwriters' inboxes.

Half of the gig workers surveyed this year by Nairobi researchers said online work was their main source of income. For them a platform's policy change is not a tech story. It is a layoff with no notice, no severance and no name.



Trainees at a Jitume digital lab. The government programme says it trained 390,968 young people in digital skills in a single year.

PHOTO: SOURCE TO BE CONFIRMED

50.3%

of gig workers surveyed rely on online work as their main income

AFIDEP SURVEY OF 857 GIG WORKERS, JUNE 2026

CHAPTER VII

Departures

The most ambitious jobs programme in Kenya does not create jobs in Kenya. Between 2022 and the first quarter of 2026 the National Employment Authority placed 583,868 Kenyans in work abroad — roughly four in five of them in Saudi Arabia, and six in ten of them women. The government's stated target is one million by December 2026.

The money comes back: diaspora remittances reached a record $5.04 billion in 2025, even as their growth slowed to the weakest in more than a decade. The risks go with the travellers. The Labour Ministry has acknowledged 185 Kenyan deaths in the Gulf in under three years, and researchers describe protection on arrival as thin.

In September 2024 a migration agreement with Germany was announced as 250,000 jobs. Berlin called the number false; the deal contains no quota. Two years on, no official count of how many Kenyans have gone under it has been published. The departure lounge at Jomo Kenyatta International remains the most honest labour office in the country.



The apron at Jomo Kenyatta International Airport, Nairobi. Roughly four in five Kenyans placed in jobs abroad since 2022 went to Saudi Arabia.

PHOTO: WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

CHAPTER VIII

The streets speak



Demonstrators march with the national flag through central Nairobi during the 2024 protests. One placard lists demands: pay doctors, fund the schools, cut public spending.

PHOTO: CAPITAL NEWS (VIDEO STILL) / WIKIMEDIA COMMONS



CHAPTER VIII · CONTINUED

Thirteen months, more than a hundred dead

The Finance Bill of June 2024 proposed VAT on bread, an annual tax on motor vehicles and higher levies on mobile-money transfers — the costs of being young, broke and mobile. The response came not from the opposition but from a generation organising itself on TikTok and X. On 25 June 2024 protesters breached Parliament; the next day the President withdrew the bill.

The cost was counted by the Kenya National Commission on Human Rights: at least 60 dead in June and July 2024, 19 on the first anniversary, and 38 on Saba Saba, 7 July 2025, when most of the dead were under 25 and 14 of 15 post-mortems found gunshot wounds. More than a hundred deaths in thirteen months, with more than a thousand arrests and dozens of abductions. In June 2026 the anniversary passed with 355 arrests and, for once, no deaths; the Finance Bill of 2026 passed only after its VAT on mobile-money fees was dropped.

The protests were about taxes. They were also about the thing the taxes were being levied on: an income that for most young Kenyans does not exist. In August 2026 the President conceded the point in his own words: “We have too many people who are jobless.”

Police and armoured water-cannon trucks in a haze of tear gas, central Nairobi, 2024.

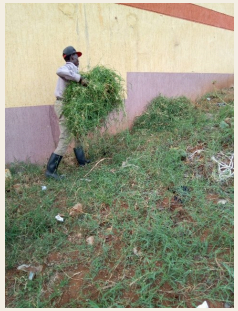
PHOTO: CAPITAL NEWS (VIDEO STILL) / WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

CHAPTER IX

Seeds

The answers on offer are many and partial. Enrolment in public technical and vocational colleges rose from 345,387 to 565,842 in two years, and the government wants two million. Climate WorX pays 46,000 young Nairobians Sh500 a day to clear drains and plant trees. A $229 million World Bank programme called NYOTA aims to reach 820,000 young people and give 100,000 of them Sh50,000 of seed capital. The National Youth Service is to grow from 18,000 recruits a year to 100,000 by 2027. The Affordable Housing Programme claims 640,000 jobs.

Set against them is the four-year ledger: about 3.27 million jobs created between 2022 and 2025, 87 per cent of them informal. The young farmer with a greenhouse, the welder with a second apprentice, the rider who has paid off his bike — these are the successes, and they are real. The question the country has not answered is whether 'informal' is a transition or a destination.



Inset A worker carries an armful of cut grass. Climate WorX pays young people Sh500 a day for manual work.

PHOTO: WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

Main A machinist at a milling machine in a training workshop. Public technical-college enrolment rose by nearly two-thirds in two years.

PHOTO: WIKIMEDIA COMMONS



AFTERWORD

What the photographs cannot show

> **Kenya does not have a shortage of work. It has a shortage of jobs — and the difference is a payslip.**

A photograph can show the rider at the stage, the welder in the sparks, the crowd on Kenyatta Avenue with the flag held high. It cannot show the WhatsApp group where three hundred graduates share one job advertisement, or the mother who sends airtime instead of rent, or the application letter rewritten for the fortieth time.

It also cannot show the statistics being gathered. The Kenya National Bureau of Statistics last published a quarterly labour-force report for the final quarter of 2022; a new national labour-force survey is planned for 2026. Until it reports, the country is arguing about its young people with numbers that are four years old.

The people in these pages are not the subjects of those numbers; they are Kenyans at work, photographed by their fellow citizens and shared freely. The essay's claim is only this: that the work is visible everywhere, and the jobs are not.

Evening traffic in central Nairobi, seen from above. At this distance the city's workers are specks, which is roughly how the statistics see them too.

PHOTO: WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

CREDITS

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